SRE Runbook Cheat Sheet For Beginners

When a production service breaks at 3 AM, you should not be guessing commands from memory. A good SRE runbook gives you exact, tested steps to diagnose and fix outages fast.

What you'll learn:

1. 1. Checking App Health Quickly
2. 2. Inspecting Error Logs in Real Time
3. 3. Spotting Resource Bottlenecks
4. 4. Safely Restarting Failed Services

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1. Checking App Health Quickly

When an alert triggers, your first step is verifying if the application is actually responding to requests. Use curl with HTTP status flags to see if the server returns 200 OK or a 500 error. Adding the -I flag fetches only headers, making it super fast.

```
$curl -I -s http://localhost:8080/health
```

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2. Inspecting Error Logs in Real Time

Most bugs show up in logs seconds before an app crashes. Instead of opening huge log files, stream the last few lines to see live errors as they happen. Combine tail with grep to filter only error lines so you do not get overwhelmed.

```
$tail -f /var/log/app.log | grep -i "error"
```

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3. Spotting Resource Bottlenecks

If the application feels slow or unresponsive, a process might be hogging CPU or RAM. Check system usage sorted by resource consumption to quickly identify runaway processes that need a restart.

```
$ps aux --sort=-%cpu | head -n 6
```

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4. Safely Restarting Failed Services

When a service locks up, a controlled restart often restores basic functionality while you investigate the root cause. Always check service status immediately after restarting to verify it came back up successfully.

```
$sudo systemctl restart my-service && systemctl status my-service
```

See Key Takeaways on next page >> linkedin.com/in/mramanrajsingh

Key Takeaways

+ Include copy-pasteable commands with clear placeholders.
+ Test runbook commands in a staging environment before using in production.
+ Link directly to relevant dashboards and alerting channels.
+ Keep step 1 as a fast health-check to confirm the alert is real.
+ Update the runbook immediately after resolving a new type of incident.

Watch Out For

! Writing vague instructions like 'check the logs' without exact file paths.
! Forgetting to list required permissions or access keys needed to fix the issue.
! Assuming the reader knows system architecture details during a 3 AM emergency.

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